

■ By Damayanti Datta

There's been a spate of horror stories about youngsters behaving outrageously. But every case has unleashed a storm of speculation over the role of parents. With conduct disorder at a record high among juniors, experts warn of the dangers and urge parents to draw the line.

One fine morning, he picked up his father's .32 mm Harrison pistol from the television trolley, stuffed it in his socks and went off to school. The nation knows what happened after that: he hid it in the school toilet, met his partner in crime, spent the day as usual, retrieved the gun after classes were done, followed the boy they had been fighting with for the last few months and opened fire. As he lay dead in a pool of blood near a garbage bin on the stairwell, the boys quietly entered their classroom and started packing their bags. They showed no remorse, no emotion. "He was a bully, threatened to kill us," they admitted. Their parents went into hiding. One set surfaced later to claim that their son was an "obedient, innocent" boy. The other (who had put up a *havan* to locate the missing gun) lamented: "We sold off property for his education. Never imagined this would be the outcome."

Is something going wrong with our children? Or have parents gone wrong somewhere while raising them? In a way, it's an unexpected legacy of New India: the way parents can't, or won't, set limits. A spate of horror stories about children behaving badly has hit the headlines this year (see box *Children on a Rampage*). But every case has unleashed a storm of speculation over the role of parents. "It's as if parents have lost their parenting skills," says Dr Jitendra Nagpal, consultant psychiatrist with Vidyasagar Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences (VIMHANS) in Delhi. And the year 2007 was a study in powerless parenting.

On October 17, the nation sat breathless as a wilful daughter brought her celebrity father to his knees. Telugu superstar, Chiranjeevi's daughter ran away from home, exchanged garlands and vows with her beloved, approached the police for protection



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